[PHOTOGRAPH]

Long boardroom table, too many chairs, too many laptops, too many coffee cups. Far end of table: one person with a single notepad and pen, no laptop. Projected slide reads: RESOURCE

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UNVARNISHED

9 Women Cannot Make a Baby in 1 Month

Serious when it matters.

What this series is

Every experienced practitioner thinks it. Almost nobody publishes it: *there has to be a better way.*

We thought it long enough that we went and built one.

Before that, we spent decades in the rooms.

The same project was failing for the third time. The proposal had arrived with twelve consultants, a competitive day rate, and a Gantt chart that implied all twelve would be productive simultaneously.

The maths looked right. The outcome was already written.

It isn't incompetence.

It's procurement doing its job perfectly, optimising for the wrong variable.

Nobody planned it this way. Nobody needed to.

We got frustrated enough to write it down. Then frustrated enough to build something.

These papers are the writing-it-down part.

The something we built is a separate conversation.

> Fred Brooks named it in 1975. Fifty years later the same meeting is still happening in the same boardroom. A project is late. The proposal on the table is more people. The logic is intuitive: if one consultant takes twelve months, twelve consultants take one month. The logic is wrong. It has always been wrong. It will be wrong the next time this meeting happens. It fails because it treats knowledge work as a production line, where capacity is fungible and output scales with headcount.

Some things take the time they take.

A baby takes nine months. Not because the process is inefficient. Because the process is sequential. There are things that cannot begin until other things are complete. There are decisions that cannot be made before the consequences of earlier decisions are understood.

A financial platform implementation has the same structure. The data model must be settled before the order management logic can be built. The order management logic must be built before the reconciliation layer can be tested. The reconciliation layer must be tested before the compliance team can begin their review. The compliance review must be complete before the UAT plan can be written.

You can have twenty people standing in the corridor waiting for each handoff. The sequence does not compress. The calendar moves at one day per day regardless of headcount.

> The irreducible sequence is not a project management problem. It is a physics problem. You cannot parallelize work that depends on the output of preceding work. Adding people to a sequential process does not accelerate it. It creates a queue.

The coordination tax.

A team of two requires one communication channel. A team of five requires ten. A team of twelve requires sixty-six.

This is not a hypothesis. It is arithmetic. Every person added to a project adds n-1 new communication channels, where n is the new team size. Each channel requires maintenance: alignment meetings, status updates, decision documentation, context transfers when someone rotates off the engagement.

The day rate spreadsheet captures twelve daily rates. It does not capture the client's internal cost of managing twelve people. It does not capture the weekly steering committee. It does not capture the three-hour alignment call that produces a document that says what everyone already agreed in the previous three-hour alignment call.

This is not a management problem. It is arithmetic operating on the wrong inputs: more people does not mean more output when the cost of connecting them exceeds the value they produce.

> The fully-loaded cost of a twelve-person consulting engagement includes the client's internal management burden, the rework generated by miscommunication across sixty-six channels, and the delay caused by decisions that cannot be made until all twelve people are in the same room. This cost does not appear on the procurement spreadsheet. It appears on the project timeline six months later.

The rework multiplier.

A wrong architectural decision in month one costs one hour to make and approximately four months to undo.

The pattern is consistent. A data model designed for one portfolio per client. Six months into the build, the requirement for multiple portfolios per client is confirmed. The data model change takes four days. The regression testing, the re-migration of historical data, and the retesting of every downstream function built on the original model takes eleven weeks. The decision that cost an hour to make costs a quarter to undo.

This is the number that never appears in the proposal. The proposal prices inputs: consultant days, travel, licensing. It does not price the probability of a wrong decision, multiplied by the cost of that decision compounded over the engagement.

The experienced practitioner recognises the decision point before it becomes a problem. They have seen the cascade that follows the wrong choice. They know which question to ask in the meeting that has not happened yet.

You are not paying a premium rate for time. You are paying for the map of the minefield. You are not paying for the map because the map is expensive. You are paying for it because it is the only thing that prevents month one from becoming month five's rework. The map was not cheap to produce. Every failed project in the practitioner's history was one of the surveys.

Everyone sees it in week two.

The warning sign is visible early. The plan requires twelve weeks of delivery work from a team already running at capacity. The maths do not work. Anyone who looks at the project plan in week two can see that week eight will fail.

Nobody says so. Not because they cannot see it. Because saying so requires a conversation that is more uncomfortable than not saying so.

The problem enters the status report as amber. Amber is the natural habitat of problems that everyone knows about and nobody wants to own. Week three: amber. Week five: amber. Week seven: amber. Day one of week eight: crisis.

The crisis produces a response. Additional people are assigned. They arrive on the morning the deliverable was due.

The person who has been doing the work now has two jobs. The first is delivering the work. The second is bringing the new arrivals up to speed on eight weeks of context, decisions, and dead ends. These two jobs are not compatible. The second displaces the first at exactly the moment the first cannot afford to be displaced.

The signal in week two was actionable. A scope adjustment, a timeline extension, an honest conversation. All cheaper than the crisis they would have prevented.

The deliverable is missed. The cost has doubled. The post-project review will recommend earlier escalation next time.

> Next time, the signal will arrive in week two. The status report will turn amber. The structural incentive has not changed: an uncomfortable conversation now versus an impossible situation later. Amber exists precisely because it lets everyone acknowledge the problem without owning it.

The procurement committee is not wrong.

A board paper that approves eight junior consultants at rate X demonstrably minimises the visible input cost. A board paper that approves two senior practitioners at 2.5X fails the line-item review on day rate alone.

The procurement committee is optimising for the metric it can measure. Day rate is measurable. Rework probability is not. Coordination overhead is not. The cost of a wrong data model decision in month one does not appear in the approval paper because nobody put it there. Nobody put it there because nobody was asked to. The approval process was designed to approve spending, not to model outcomes.

This is not a failure of the procurement system. It is the procurement system performing exactly as designed, measuring exactly what it was built to measure, and producing a decision that looks correct in the room and looks catastrophic eighteen months later.

> The argument for premium rates is not that senior practitioners work harder. It is that they make fewer decisions that need to be reversed. Every reversed decision in a financial platform implementation carries a multiplier: the work undone, the work redone, the downstream work that was built on the wrong foundation and must now also be rebuilt. A single avoided reversal typically costs more than the rate differential for the entire engagement.

Before the next proposal lands on your desk, two questions.

The proposal will show you a day rate, a team size, a timeline. Ask instead: what is the probability that a decision made in month one will need to be reversed in month five? And what does that reversal cost, fully loaded?

Then ask the second question: if the signal arrives in week two that resources will be insufficient in week eight, what is the cost of naming it then rather than discovering it on day one of week eight?

If the proposal cannot answer either question, it is a resourcing schedule dressed as a project plan. They look identical in a board paper. They produce very different outcomes at go-live.

> Nine women cannot make a baby in one month. Some things take the time they take. The only variable you control is whether the person doing the work has seen the path before. The same distribution that removes accountability removes capacity.

This paper is part of the Unvarnished series — field notes from decades of bad projects. The series is published by InvestPuppy. For the full series and other work visit investpuppy.com.